

CONCEPT NOTE 2021

SDG 4 MONITORING PLAN OF ACTION



Headquarters: Accra-Ghana
P. O. Box M274, Accra-Ghana

✉ secgen@aasuonline.org | info@aasuonline.org

🌐 www.aasuonline.org ☎ +233 302 547 128

📞 +233242879028 | +233502672146

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BACKGROUND

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The Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) number 4 is to “ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all” and has seven targets. Generally, over the years, many governmental and non-governmental organizations have made efforts to develop tools that can be used to measure or monitor the progress of many countries in achieving this goal. However, these tools have not been successful in providing appropriate and reliable data that can assist African governments to measure their progress towards achieving SDG 4. Meanwhile, it is important to continue the search for tools that are adaptable yet reliable, valid, cost-efficient and easy to use at scale (UNESCO, 2020). Such tools are critical to providing reliable data for measuring progress. Moreover, with about nine (9) years remaining to achieve the SDGs, it is imperative that African governments are aware of their progress towards achieving the SDG 4. In view of this, the SDG 4 Monitoring Project seeks to develop a comprehensive framework for measuring quality in the context of Africa from the perspective of students. This information is necessary given that students are in a relatively better position to judge the quality of services delivered compared with the teachers and other deliverers of the service. With a specific focus on the UN SDG 4, this project brings together student and youth activist to collect data in the 54 African countries to provide an evidence based report on the SDG 4 in Africa.

Ideally, a regional monitoring framework with regional indicators would be a preferred system for monitoring the progress of SDG 4 in Africa. However, due to differences in the development of education sectors in different African countries, a national level monitoring of SDG 4 will be employed. This will allow for the inclusion of country-specific indicators that will ease the assessment of country-specific progress as well as regional progress.

OBJECTIVES

GENERAL OBJECTIVES

The main aim of this project is to monitor the progress of African Countries in achieving the SDG 4 from the perspective of students. Specifically, the project seeks to:

1. Develop a comprehensive monitoring and evaluation system for monitoring the progress of SDG 4 in Africa
2. Evaluate the current quality of education received by African students
3. Assess the effectiveness of various country-specific educational policies aimed at achieving SDG 4

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE PROJECT

This project will provide information that policymakers can use to address the challenges or bottlenecks in African education sector. The outcome of the project will also provide knowledge on the current progress of African countries in the education sector as well as towards achieving SDG4. The project will provide indicators which development partners can use to initiate interventions that are geared towards enhancing quality education in Africa. Based on the outcome of the project, policymakers and development partners alike can design capacity development programmes that can supplement the quality of education received by African students. The outcome of the project will provide information that can be used by students' unions and student leaders in different countries to hold their governments accountable and demand quality education in different aspects. The project is also expected to add to the body of knowledge on the effectiveness of different country-specific educational policies towards achieving quality education.

METHODOLOGY

NEEDS

The project intends to collect data from at least 1,620 classrooms across Africa. This will comprise 30 classrooms from each of the 54 countries. The target schools will include both government and private schools. Data will be collected from students at the pre-tertiary level and will include students from Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) institutes. Where necessary, students' report cards will be solicited to ascertain their literacy and numeracy skills through their performance (scores) in English Language and Mathematics.

The students will assess the quality of educational materials received (both teaching and learning materials), the level of infrastructural development in school (both physical and communication) as well as the quality of teaching received.

Quality of educational material received will be measured in terms of the number of books received per subject/unit/ course and to what extent these educational materials are relevant to their subjects of study.

METHODOLOGY

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NEEDS

Level of infrastructural development will be measured in terms of students' access to basic drinking water, single-sex basic sanitation facilities and basic handwashing facilities, access to electricity, the Internet for pedagogical purposes and computers for pedagogical purposes and availability of adapted infrastructure and materials for students with disabilities.

The quality of teaching will be assessed using quality assurance indicators. Further, students will give their views on the subject of the type of learning environment. That is, whether they are experiencing positive and stimulating school learning environments. Positive and stimulating school environments will be measured on the lines of students' experiences with bullying, corporal punishment, harassment, violence, sexual discrimination and abuse. Further, students' skills set will be assessed to ascertain the quality of training received by these students.

Equitable education will be measured on the lines of parity indices (female/male, rural/ urban, bottom/top wealth quintile and others such as disability status and conflict-affected as data becomes available) for all education indicators on this list that can be disaggregated

DATA COLLECTION

The project seeks to track the progress of SDG 4 in Africa from the perspective of students. On this basis, a structured questionnaire will be used as the main data collection tool to collect data on the major indicators. The data collection process will begin with a pilot test to validate and assess the reliability of the proposed indicators and the data collection tool in general.

RESOURCES

Key resources required in this project are financial and human resources. Financial resources are needed to facilitate data collection in multiple countries. Also, the assistance of country representatives of the All-Africa Students Union (leaders of national students unions) will be needed to coordinate data collection exercises.

KEY PARTNERS

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MILLENNIUM PROMISE

Millennium Promise seeks to accelerate sustainable development and eradicate poverty across rural sub-Saharan Africa and beyond. They institutionalize their approach in the sub-Saharan Africa and beyond by collaborating with partners in research and applied field work. This makes them ideal partners for the project.



GHANA EDUCATION SERVICE

Ghana Education Service is governmental institution GES responsible for the implementation of approved national pre-tertiary educational policies and programs to ensure that all Ghanaian children of school-going age irrespective of tribe, gender, disability, religious and political affiliations are provided with inclusive and equitable quality formal education. Their involvement in the project would be relevant for broad perspective and indulgence of government on the subject matter.



Association of
African Universities
Association des universités africaines
Association of African Universities

ASSOCIATION OF AFRICAN UNIVERSITIES

The Association of African Universities (AAU) is an international non-profit, non-governmental organization created by African universities to promote cooperation between them on the one hand, and between them and the international academic community on the other. AAU is the Implementing arm of the African Union Commission on Higher Education matters and the Coordinator of The Continental Education Strategy for Africa (CESA-16-25). Created in 1967, the AAU is also the voice of higher education in Africa. It aims to improve the quality of African higher education, and to strengthen its contribution to Africa's development by supporting the core functions of higher education institutions and facilitating critical reflection and consensus building on issues affecting higher education in Africa. Proven their expertise in higher education across the African continent, they will be a key partner to this project.



UNESCO

UNESCO, as one of the staunch organizations championing the SDG 4 would be a key partner to this project through technical and financial support. UNESCO as an organization seeks to build peace through international cooperation in Education, the Sciences and Culture. UNESCO's programmes contribute significantly to the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals defined in Agenda 2030, adopted by the UN General Assembly in 2015. As this project is focused on SDG 4, partnering with UNESCO will bring significant achievement in the expected outcome

PROJECT TIMELINE

Activity/ Month	Jan	Feb	Mar	April	May	June	July	August	September
Concept Note									
Data collection tools									
Pilot test									
Data Collection									
Data Cleaning									
Data Analysis									
Report									

EXPECTED OUTCOMES

1.

A technical report

2.

Policy brief(s)

AASU is the largest student movement in Africa and a very dominant force on the Continent and beyond. The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) organizes all students in Africa from the basic level to Institutions of higher learning; in essence, the Union is the umbrella organization for all students of Africa. Since its inception in 1972, AASU now has presence in 54 Countries in Africa. As the Continent's largest students group, AASU played an important role in the struggle against colonialism and the ending of apartheid. Today, AASU is at the forefront of the fights for equal access to quality education, quality assurance in higher education, harmonization of higher education systems with key emphasis on mobility of students and academics, and comparability of qualifications, democratic governance, defending students' rights, promotion of gender and African culture, sustainable development, entrepreneurship, fostering of academic freedom, freedom of research and autonomy of higher institutions of learning, and the promotion of peace and democratic values, and other noteworthy objectives. In the year 2000, the United Nations (UN) awarded AASU a certificate of merit in recognition of the Union's efforts at advancing students' rights and championing the democratization of education across the African Continent.

Our strategic approach is to address the crucial issues affecting African students and young people, as such, we have identified Seven (7) Strategic Priorities to guide our work at the Secretariat in accordance with the aims and objectives of the Union. AASU's Strategic Priorities are fully aligned to the UN and AU's development priorities as articulated in the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and Agenda 2063 respectively. In addition, these priorities complement the global efforts to build a relevant contemporary human capital, capable of fitting into the global citizen ecosystem.

STRATEGIC PRIORITIES OF THE ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION

The Seven (7) Strategic Priorities of the Union are:

GENDER ADVOCACY
ENVIRONMENT & CLIMATE ACTION
DEMOCRACY & GOOD GOVERNANCE
CAPACITY BUILDING
MIGRATION & MOBILITY
EDUCATION & STUDENTS RIGHTS
PAN-AFRICANISM & AFRICAN CULTURE



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www.aasuonline.org



info@aasuonline.org